Focal
Speed Reading

Reading Without Barriers

Investor Brief • 2026

A free, open, offline-capable Rapid Serial Visual Presentation (RSVP) platform

built for people with reading disabilities - and used by everyone.

Executive Summary

MISSION	To make reading accessible to everyone - starting with the people who need it most.

One in five people has a reading disability. For hundreds of millions of people worldwide, the act of reading - the foundational skill on which education, employment, and civic life depend - is genuinely, neurologically difficult. Not because of lack of intelligence or effort. Because the format in which we deliver text was designed for people whose brains process it easily and never reconsidered for those who do not.

Focal is a Rapid Serial Visual Presentation (RSVP) platform that changes the format. Rather than asking readers to scan a page - a process that requires precise saccadic eye movement, visual tracking, crowding-noise management, and phonological processing in parallel - Focal brings the text to the reader. One word. One place. One moment at a time.

Research by Forster (1970) and Potter (1984) demonstrated that RSVP allows processing rates of 700+ WPM for trained readers. With Focal's Optimal Recognition Point alignment, intelligent adaptive pacing, and full accessibility toolkit, that potential is now available to everyone - especially those who need it most.

1 in 5	80%	$300B+	30%
People have a reading disability	of all learning disabilities are reading-related	annual economic cost in the U.S. alone	of reading time is spent just moving eyes

The Problem

Reading Disabilities Are Common, Underserved, and Costly

Specific Learning Disabilities (SLDs) in reading - the clinical umbrella that includes dyslexia, visual processing disorders, processing speed deficits, and related conditions - are among the most prevalent and impactful cognitive differences in the world.

- Dyslexia alone affects an estimated 10–20% of the global population.
- Fewer than half of individuals with dyslexia are formally identified; many carry the label of being a “poor reader” for their entire lives.
- Adults with dyslexia are three times more likely to be unemployed than their neurotypical peers.
- Reading disabilities are the primary driver of academic underperformance and disproportionately represented in dropout and incarceration statistics.
- The total economic cost of reading disabilities in the U.S. alone exceeds $300 billion annually.

The Digital Age Has Made It Worse

Reading is now the primary interface through which people access employment opportunities, civic information, healthcare systems, financial products, and education. Email. Contracts. News. Code. Benefits forms. Every one of these is text-first, and every one of them assumes a reader for whom scanning a page is effortless.

Existing accommodation - text-to-speech, dyslexia fonts, screen magnification - reduce friction. They do not change the fundamental format. RSVP changes the format.

KEY INSIGHT	The problem is not the reader. The problem is the format. A wall of text was never designed for 20% of the population - and the digital age has made text the surface on which everything happens.

The Science

How the Brain Reads - and Where It Breaks Down

Traditional reading requires a complex, parallel series of cognitive operations performed automatically by fluent readers. The eyes make 3–4 rapid movements called saccades per second across a line of text, each followed by a fixation during which the brain processes a cluster of words.

20–30ms	200–300ms	30%	700+ WPM
per saccade (eye movement)	per fixation (processing pause)	of reading time spent on eye movement alone	achievable with trained RSVP (Potter, 1984)

For people with dyslexia, one or more steps in the reading pipeline require conscious effort - turning what should be automatic into an exhausting cognitive task. For people with visual processing disorders, the page itself is the problem: letters crowd and shift, lines blur, and the visual input is not processed cleanly. RSVP removes both failure modes at the source.

Optimal Recognition Point (ORP)

Research by Brysbaert & Nazir (1998) identified the Optimal Recognition Point: the specific character position within each word where the brain's lexical recognition fires most rapidly. This is not the center of the word - it is slightly left of center, varying by word length:

- Short words (1–5 letters): ORP near character position 2
- Longer words: ORP shifts right but stays in the first third - where the most informative letters appear.

Focal aligns every word to its ORP at a fixed screen position. The highlighted character in the display marks this point. The reader's visual system never searches for where to look - every word arrives exactly where recognition is fastest.

Intelligent Pacing Engine

Focal goes beyond fixed-interval display. Its timing engine adapts to content in real time:

- Longer words receive proportionally more display time, preventing truncated processing.
- Punctuation triggers natural pauses - a period adds a half-beat, simulating natural speech cadence.
- Paragraph breaks introduce longer pauses, giving the brain the mental reset it expects between sections.

The result is a reading experience that feels like reading - not like watching a ticker tape.

Multi-Language ORP Support

Focal’s recognition point logic is script-aware, extending the accessibility reach to a global user base:

Script / Language Group	ORP Adaptation
Latin (English, French, Spanish, German...)	Standard Brysbaert-Nazir position
Cyrillic (Russian, Ukrainian, Bulgarian...)	Adapted for Cyrillic character frequency distribution
CJK (Chinese, Japanese, Korean)	Character-level fixation; no sub-character decoding needed
Arabic / Farsi / Urdu	Right-to-left adapted; root-morpheme weighted fixation
Devanagari (Hindi, Sanskrit, Nepali...)	Matra-aware fixation logic

Research Foundation

Forster, K.I. (1970). Visual perception of rapidly presented word sequences of varying complexity. Perception & Psychophysics, 8(4), 215–221.

Potter, M.C. (1984). Rapid serial visual presentation (RSVP): A method for studying language processing. In Kieras & Just (Eds.), New methods in reading comprehension research. Erlbaum.

Brysbaert, M. & Nazir, T. (1998). Visual constraints in written word recognition: Evidence from the optimal viewing-position effect. Journal of Research in Reading, 21(3), 216–230.

From Research Lab to Spritz to Focal

The Research Era (1960s–2000s)

RSVP as a reading paradigm emerged from cognitive psychology in the 1960s. Forster (1970) and Potter (1984) established it as a rigorous method for studying reading cognition. Brysbaert & Nazir (1998) quantified the ORP. For decades, the technique remained in the laboratory - genuinely useful, but without a delivery mechanism to reach the people who needed it.

Spritz: The Proof of Concept (2012–2016)

In 2014, Spritz Technologies launched publicly with integrations into Samsung's Galaxy S5 and Gear 2 - screens too small for traditional reading. Their demo showing users reading at 500 WPM within seconds of introduction went massively viral, proving three things: RSVP is immediately intuitive, general audiences respond strongly, and the technology has real commercial appeal.

But Spritz revealed the ceiling of a first-generation, venture-backed RSVP product:

- Proprietary and licensed - free access was restricted.
- No text import - limited to Spritz-partnered content.
- No customization - speed, display, and font were fixed.
- No accessibility focus - built for speed, not inclusion.
- No offline capability
- Abandoned - Spritz went quiet by the late 2010s.

The RSVP Ecosystem (2015–Present)

Following Spritz's viral moment, a small ecosystem of minimal tools emerged - browser extensions, basic apps, and web utilities. Most treated RSVP as a speed trick. None addressed the full picture: the user with dyslexia who needs an Open Dyslexic font and a tinted background; the user with ADHD who needs a session timer; the user with processing speed deficits who reads at 80 WPM and needs the tool to meet them there without judgment.

Focal: The Platform RSVP Always Needed

Focal addresses everything the prior generation left undone. It is the first RSVP platform designed accessibility-first, built well enough that it serves everyone.

Competitive Landscape

Feature	Spritz (2014)	RSVP Tools	Focal
Offline / no install required	No	Partial	**Yes ✓**
Free and open	No	Partial	**Yes ✓**
ORP alignment	Yes	Rarely	**Yes ✓**
Intelligent adaptive pacing	No	No	**Yes ✓**
Speed range (WPM)	100–600	100–500	**50–1000 ✓**
Multi-language ORP (5 scripts)	No	No	**Yes ✓**
Chunked reading (1–3 words)	No	Rarely	**Yes ✓**
Dyslexia font (Open Dyslexic)	No	Rarely	**Yes ✓**
Custom background palette	No	No	**Full 2D picker ✓**
Dark / light / high contrast	No	Partial	**Yes ✓**
Text import (TXT/PDF/EPUB/DOCX/MD/RTF/HTML/CSV/URL)	No	Partial	**Yes ✓**
Touch controls (tap/swipe)	No	Partial	**Yes ✓**
AI analysis / summarization	No	No	**Yes ✓**
Sentence context + click-to-seek	No	No	**Yes ✓**
Pomodoro focus timer	No	No	**Yes ✓**
Session stats + AI insights (live)	No	No	**Yes ✓**
Psychometric diagnostics (6 metrics)	No	No	**Yes ✓**
Interactive graded quizzes (MC/TF/FIB)	No	No	**Yes ✓**
Gamification (streaks/goals/milestones)	No	No	**Yes ✓**
Session persistence across refresh	No	No	**Yes ✓**
Zen reading mode	No	No	**Yes ✓**
Status (2025)	Abandoned	Minimal	**Active ✓**

The Accessibility Principle

Built for the Few. Used by Everyone.

The most important insight in Focal's investment thesis is not about dyslexia. It is about the pattern of innovation that dyslexia-first design represents.

Throughout modern history, the most widely adopted technologies in daily use were not invented for the mainstream. They were invented for people at the margins - and then they went everywhere.

Technology	Original Accessibility Purpose → Mass Adoption
Typewriter (1860s)	Enabled blind users to write independently → became the universal office tool
Telephone	Early concepts included enabling deaf users to communicate → global infrastructure
Audiobooks (1930s)	American Foundation for the Blind → $4B+ industry driven by sighted commuters
Closed captioning (1970s)	Deaf and hard-of-hearing viewers → millions watching videos in public, noisy spaces
Curb cuts	Required by disability advocates for wheelchair access → cyclists, parents, delivery workers
Autocorrect	Originally a keyboard accessibility feature for motor-impaired users → every smartphone
Voice assistants (Siri, Alexa)	Motor and visual accessibility → mainstream consumer products, billions of users
Email read receipts	Developed in accessibility contexts → universal business communication feature

This phenomenon is called the Curb Cut Effect: design for margins, improve the centre.

THESIS	RSVP technology follows the same arc. Studying for decades as a tool for readers for whom standard text was inaccessible. Focal makes it available to everyone - with the people who need it most at the centre of the design, not the footnote.

The commercial logic is direct: a tool built with genuine accessibility rigor is also, necessarily, a tool built with exceptional attention to customization, flexibility, and user experience. Accessibility requirements are the most demanding UX brief in existence. When you solve them, you solve them for everyone.

The Product

A Platform, not a Feature

Focal is a single-file Progressive Web App. It installs on any device, works fully offline, and requires no account, subscription, or infrastructure to use. All user data - preferences, library texts, session history - is stored in localStorage and IndexedDB on the device. Nothing leaves the browser.

Core Reading Engine

- ORP-aligned word presentation at 50–1000 WPM
- Intelligent pacing: adaptive timing for word length, punctuation, and paragraph breaks
- 1, 2, or 3-word chunk modes for different comprehension preferences
- Ramp mode - gradual speed acceleration from a configurable starting pace.
- **Reading Display Mode** - typography adapts to cognitive goal: Scan (light Inter, open spacing) for high-WPM skimming, Deep (bold Georgia serif) for comprehension, Auto switches in real-time based on WPM.
- Full progress scrubbing and word-level navigation
- Sentence context view with click-to-seek on any word.
- Multi-language ORP: Latin, Cyrillic, CJK, Arabic, Devanagari

Accessibility Layer

- Two clinically designed accessible fonts: **Open Dyslexic** (weighted letter bottoms prevent b/d/p/q reversal) and **Atkinson Hyperlegible** (maximized inter-character differentiation for low vision) one-click toggle.
- Full 2D hue × saturation background palette with depth and temperature control
- High contrast mode and adjustable font size
- Dark / light themes with per-theme color inheritance
- Accent color customization with color-blind-friendly presets.
- prefers-reduced-motion: all animations suppressed at OS level when requested.
- Full ARIA labelling, aria-live word announcement, keyboard-only and touch navigation

Intelligence Layer

- AI analysis powered by Groq (Llama 3.3 70B) ultra-low latency inference.
- Interactive quizzes: multiple-choice, true/false, fill-in-the-blank - AI-generated, auto-graded, scores tracked per text.

- Summarize, Key Points, Explain Simply, Reading Level, Comprehension Check
- AI Psychometric Insights: clinical-quality analysis referencing Hasbrouck & Tindal norms and DIBELS framework.
- Import from TXT, PDF (PDF.js), EPUB (JSZip), DOCX (Mammoth.js), Markdown, RTF, HTML, CSV, and URL fetch.

Psychometric Diagnostics

- Consistency (CV%): WPM coefficient of variation - flags attention and decoding issues
- Avg Focus: sustained attention span measured between play and pause events.
- Regressions: backward navigation rate per 1,000 words - comprehension difficulty indicator
- Stamina: WPM decline ratio within sessions - measures reading fatigue
- Comprehension: average score across graded interactive quizzes
- Effective WPM: speed × comprehension - the gold-standard composite measure

Engagement & Retention

- Gamification: daily streak, configurable reading goal (5–60 min), milestone badges (100 → 250K words)
- Three-tab interface: Read (sacred reading surface), Learn (testing + analysis), Stats (psychometric dashboard)
- Zen mode: distraction-free reading with faded controls, activated by keystroke.
- Focus Timer in header: full Pomodoro with rounds, long breaks, auto-start, progress ring.
- Session persistence: loaded text, position, and timer state survive page refresh - zero data loss.
- **Structured onboarding** - first-run 14-day training ramp (200 → 250 → 300+ WPM) with progress bar, calibration session, and daily training day counter grounded in RSVP adaptation research.
- **Guided feature tour** - 6-step spotlight walkthrough on first launch highlights every key surface with a glowing focus ring and contextual popover; state persisted locally.
- **Contextual tooltips** - every setting carries an inline explanation covering what it does, the science behind it, and when to use it; zero documentation required.
- Granular data control: independently clear session log, daily activity, quiz scores, bookmarks, library, or timer stats

Market Opportunity

1.3B	800M	$15.4B	12.3%
people with a disability globally (WHO)	adults with low literacy or reading difficulty	assistive technology market size (2024)	assistive tech CAGR through 2030

Primary Markets

- People with dyslexia and reading disabilities (est. 700M+ globally)
- Students with IEPs and 504 plans requiring reading accommodation.
- Adults with ADHD seeking focus and comprehension support
- Non-native language readers manage cognitive load in a second language.
- Professionals managing high-volume reading: legal, medical, research, finance.
- Commuters and mobile users consuming long-form content.

Distribution Advantage

Because Focal is free and single file, it distributes through any channel: school districts, hospital patient portals, corporate HR platforms, public library systems, government accessibility programs. There is no friction. No download. No account. You share a link and it works.

Business Model

The core Focal application is and will remain free. This is not a limitation - it is the distribution strategy. The widest possible reach is the asset.

Revenue Streams

- **Focal Pro:** Premium tier - advanced AI features, team libraries, cross-device sync
- **Focal for Education:** School district licensing with teacher dashboards, reading progress tracking, and IEP integration.
- **Focal for Enterprise:** Workplace accessibility compliance tooling; LMS and knowledge management platform integrations
- **API Access:** RSVP rendering as a service for publishers, e-reading platforms, and content delivery networks
- **Partnerships:** Integration licensing with accessibility-mandated platforms in government, healthcare, and education

MODEL	Free at the base. Institutional and enterprise revenue above. The people who need it most pay nothing. The organizations that serve them do.

Vision

Reading is not just a skill. It is the mechanism by which human beings access knowledge, opportunity, and participation in society. When 20% of the population is locked out of that mechanism - not by choice, not by laziness, but by the arbitrary way we have decided to display text - the loss is immeasurable.

Focal is not an app. It is a redefinition of the reading surface. The page was designed for the printing press. It has been inherited by every screen without question. We are questioning it.

The technologies that change how human beings interact with information are not always the loudest ones. Sometimes they are a single word, in exactly the right place, at exactly the right time.

Focal - Reading Without Barriers

The Ask

We are seeking seed-stage investment to fund:

- Product: iOS and Android native apps; Focal for Education platform; API infrastructure
- Research: Formal clinical validation studies with SLD populations; university research partnerships
- Distribution: School district and enterprise sales; accessibility organization partnerships
- Team: Engineering, accessibility research, and growth

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